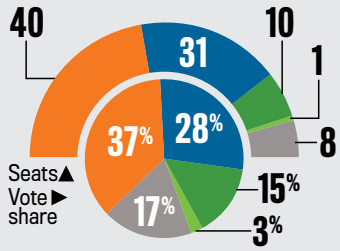
THE POLL KURUKSHETRA

PAST SPOILS

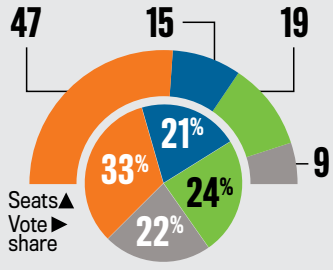
How parties performed in last two state elections

Total seats: 90

ASSEMBLY 2019



ASSEMBLY 2014



BJP Cong JJP
INLD Others

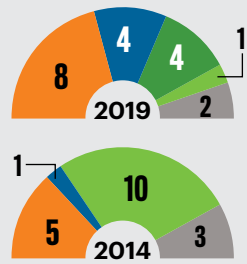
Vote share figures have been rounded off

THE BATTLE ZONES

Each region presents its own set of opportunities and challenges to the main competitors

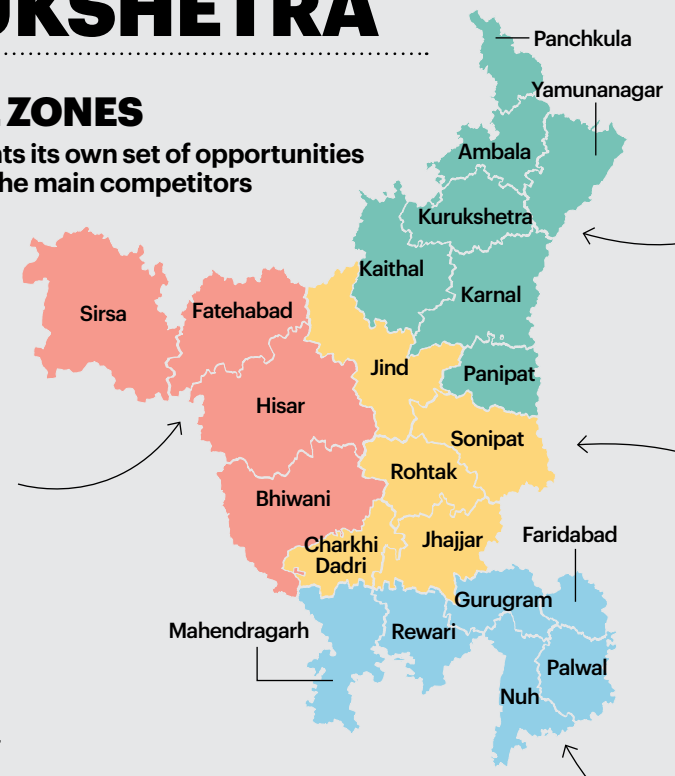
BAGAR REGION

Total seats: 19



BIG FACTORS

- This erstwhile Chautala fiefdom is witnessing multi-cornered contests
- JJP-INLD's Jat base is shifting towards the Congress while the BJP is eyeing their non-Jat support base
- Jailed 'godman' Gurmeet Ram Rahim enjoys maximum clout here, especially among Dalits, and he is apparently backing the BJP



The BJP wants to make this election more localised. Modi, the biggest draw in the past, has addressed only two rallies so far

Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

(Dalit's daughter) proved the Congress was an "anti-Dalit" party. Just before this, fellow Union minister and former Haryana CM Manohar Lal Khattar had claimed the BJP was "ready with an offer" for the Congress MP. Would Haryana, too, see a high-profile defection, a la Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra? That too of an old Gandhi family loyalist? Selja rubbished the speculation the same evening, though admitting that she was "hurt".

A high-stakes battle is unfolding in Haryana and even a tiny alteration to the collective mood ahead of the voting on October 5 can have a significant effect on the final numbers. The factionalism notwithstanding, the Congress's morale is up: in June, it had wrested five of the 10 parliamentary seats in what had been a solid saffron bastion since 2014. That general narrative of anti-incumbency is intact. To encash it, the Congress is banking heavily on the consolidation of the Jat-Muslim-Dalit vote in its favour while looking for chinks in the BJP's umbrella coalition of non-Jat and Other Backward Classes (OBCs), which it has been assiduously cultivating to stack on top of its old base of urban forward castes.

It's the presumed mobility of the Dalits that brings in novelty: they account for over a fifth of the population, but don't have a set voting pattern. While there are only 17 reserved seats, any swing in the Dalit vote can change the outcome in 49 of the 90 assembly seats. In the Lok Sabha election, Haryana's Dalit voters followed a larger national trend, shifting in bulk from the saffron fold to the Congress on the question of the Constitution. The BJP's loss in the state's two reserved constituencies, Sirsa and Ambala, only put a visible face to that.

Will that chess piece move again? It seemed improbable, but BJP strategists have been chipping away at it. With a